Changing or Deleting a Subject Authority Record

H 193

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A. Background

In most cases, a subject heading is changed from one form to another by changing the data in the 1XX field of the subject authority record, rather than by deleting the subject authority record and creating a new one. These changes must be proposed by a cataloger and submitted to the Policy, Training, and Cooperative Programs Division (PTCP) of the Library of Congress. If the change proposal is approved during PTCP's editorial process, the heading in its new form retains the same authority record control number (010 field) that was assigned to the old heading, and the old heading becomes a 4XX field (UF reference) in the authority record, coded to indicate that it is the earlier form of the current heading. If the earlier heading appears as a broader term or related term (5XX field) in other subject authority records, or if it has been used as an example in a general see or see also reference or scope note, it is changed (via additional proposals) in those records as well.

However, if a single heading is "split" into two or more new headings, the original authority record is deleted, and new authority records are created for the new headings using new record control numbers. Authority records are also deleted in cases where duplication of records occurs.

This instruction sheet describes the procedures for making a proposal to change a subject heading from one form to another or to delete a subject authority record. These procedures are presented in terms applicable to the Classification Web Plus Subject Heading Proposal System.

B. Recent revisions

2026-04: Added information on making associated changes and defining projects.

C. Definitions

Changing a subject authority record: A change to the heading (1XX), Used For references (4XX), Broader or Related Terms (5XX), or scope notes (680), which are appropriate reasons to make a proposal to change a subject authority record.

Deleting a subject authority record: Replacing a subject authority record with a name authority record, or with multiple other subject authority records, or erasing it entirely from the subject authority file, which are appropriate reasons to make a proposal to cancel a subject authority record.

D. Changing an authority record

D.1. Retrieving the heading in the ClassWeb Plus Subject Heading Proposal System

In order to change a subject heading to a new form, retrieve the heading in the ClassWeb Plus Subject Heading Proposal System. Click on the icon to the right of the heading in the browse display, and in the dropdown menu, click "Propose a change to this record."

D.2. Geographic subdivision

See H 364 for guidelines on coding to indicate whether a heading may be subdivided geographically or not. If it is necessary to change the coding for the record in question, do so by selecting the appropriate radio button. The values that appear as radio buttons for the 008/06 field are as follows:

- May Subd Geog = Subdivided geographically - indirect
- Not Subd Geog = Not subdivided geographically
- No Attempt to Code (This value also indicates that the heading is not currently divided geographically)

D.3. "Generated by"

At the top of the form select the appropriate radio button from the four options. See H 200 sec. D.1 for definitions of the options.

D.4. Changing an authority record: Adjusting the 1XX field

Change the heading in the 1XX field to the desired form.

D.5. Changing an authority record: Adjusting the references

D.5.a. Former heading

Except as stated below, add a 4XX field containing the old form of the heading. Identify this as the earlier form of the heading by adding to the field a $w control subfield containing the data nne. Place the control subfield before the $a subfield. The $w subfield generates the notations ***[Change heading]*** on the tentative list and ***[Former heading]*** in *Library of Congress Subject Headings*.

Omit this special 4XX field under the following circumstances:

- when the old form of heading "normalizes" to the same string of characters as the new form; that is, when the old form is identical in all respects to the new form except for capitalization, diacritics, hyphens, etc. (Note, however, that when a hyphen is removed

from a heading and the hyphenated words are changed to a single word, the 4XX from the old form should be made);

- when the only change being made is the correction of a typographical error in the old form of heading;
- when the only change being made is the closing of what had been an open date in the heading or in a period subdivision under the heading;
- when a *[heading]–[subdivision]* record is being changed because the basic heading itself is also being changed, and the 4XX field containing the old form of the heading has been added to the authority record for the basic heading. For example, when ***Venereal diseases*** was changed to ***Sexually transmitted diseases***, a 4XX field with the form ***Venereal diseases*** was added to that record. Therefore, a 4XX with the form ***Venereal diseases–Eclectic treatment*** was not added when that heading was changed to ***Sexually transmitted diseases–Eclectic treatment***.

D.5.b. Review all references

Review the 4XX and 5XX fields to determine whether they conform to current policies for making references (cf. H 370-H 375). If any field is incorrect or inappropriate, change it or delete it as necessary. Add any additional 4XX or 5XX fields that may be required. See sec. D.7 of this instruction sheet for more guidance.

D.6. Classification number

Review any 053 field(s) present in the record. See H 365 for guidelines on LC classification numbers in subject authority records. If any 053 is incorrect, change or delete it as necessary. If a required 053 field is not present, add it to the record.

D.7. Authority research information

Use 670, 675, and 952 fields to provide source citations, LC patterns, etc., applicable to the new form of the heading, following the guidelines in H 203 *Citation of Sources* and the procedures in H 200, sec. D.6 and D.12. Do not delete or revise existing 670 fields.

If you are adding information from a resource that has already been cited, do not modify the existing information. However, if it is a print resource, you may add information from that same resource to the end of its original 670 citation. If it is an online resource, then a separate 670, with a new date viewed, should be added. If it is a digitized version of a print resource available online, treat it as an online resource.

Ensure all UFs, including older UFs, are supported by source citations in the 670 fields, performing research and recording additional 670 fields as needed. If, however, no support is

found for the older UFs, and they are not incorrect or inappropriate, do not delete them. Add a 675 to indicate no support was found to justify the existing variants.

Example:

```
675 ## $a Reference source searched, pubdate. No support found for UF, UF,
      UF.
```

D.8. Other fields

Add or edit any other fields as necessary, such as the 260, 360, 680, and 781 fields. Follow the procedures described in H 200, sec. D.7-D.10. For examples of content designation of 260 and 360 fields, see H 374 *General See References* and H 371 *General See Also References*. For examples of 680 and 781 fields, see H 400, and H 836, respectively.

D.9. Bibliographic file maintenance

Indicate the total number of bibliographic records that will need to be updated as a result of the proposed change by adding a 952 field formatted as in the following example:

Example:

```
952 ## $a Bib. records to be changed: 75
```

If this field is already present in the record, edit it to reflect the number of bibliographic records being submitted with the current proposal. Do not add a second field of this type.

D.10. Saving and viewing the record

Save the proposed revision to the ClassWeb Plus Subject Heading Proposal System by clicking on the wrench icon in the upper right-hand corner to reveal the Tools menu and clicking the Save button. The proposed revision is now searchable within the system. Search for the proposed heading in the browse display. The text of the heading is displayed in brown, indicating that it is a proposed revision and not yet approved.

D.11. Associated changes

D.11.a. Change headings in 5XX fields in other records

Locate all authority records in which the heading being changed has been used as a broader or related term, that is, those headings that are printed as NTs or RTs in *Library of Congress Subject Headings* under the heading being changed.

Retrieve each authority record in the Subject Heading Proposal System as described in sec. D.1, above. In each record, change the data in the 5XX field from the old form of the heading to the new form, or delete the field if the reference is no longer valid under current guidelines (see H

370). Follow the procedures described in H 195 *Changing References in Subject Authority Records*.

Note: If other obvious errors are present in any of these records, such as incorrect class numbers, invalid 4XX or 5XX fields, etc., correct these errors at the same time, insofar as this can be done within a reasonable length of time and without doing extensive research. It is not required to determine whether all existing references conform to current policy so that they may be coded as "evaluated" (cf. H 370, Background).

D.11.b. Change headings used as an example in other records

If the heading being changed has been used as an example in a 260 field (general see reference), 360 field (general see also reference), or 680 field (scope note) in another record, there is a 681 field in the record that says, "Example under [. . .]" or "Note under [. . .]." If this field is present revise those records as well.

D.11.c. Proposals that become a project

PTCP manages the number of LCSH/LCC projects that are included on monthly tentative lists. Individuals making proposals should assess whether they are creating a new project before submitting proposals. LCSH/LCC projects are defined as 20 or more proposals on a similar theme or a proposal to update a base heading that will result in changes to more than 10 headings or classification numbers.

Catalogers or SACO funnels who would like a project to be considered for inclusion on a tentative list should contact PTCP for assistance by emailing saco@loc.gov. LC catalogers should reach out to PTCP via policy@loc.gov. Also see the instructions at SACO Projects.

If a cataloger submits more than 10 proposals to be considered a project without informing PTCP ahead of time, PTCP will reserve the option to re-schedule those proposals to a special list to be handled at our convenience.

D.12. Submitting the proposal

Submit the proposal(s) to PTCP according to the instructions in H 200 sec. D15. Once the proposal(s) have been submitted to PTCP using the Submit for Review button, it is not possible to make further changes to the online authority records in the Subject Heading Proposal System. If any additions or changes need to be made after the proposal has been forwarded, LC catalogers may send an additional email explaining the change to proposals@loc.gov and SACO members may email saco@loc.gov.

E. Deleting an authority record

Normally, a subject authority record may be deleted only if either: (a) the heading duplicates a name heading; (b) the heading is replaced by a heading already represented by another subject authority record; or (c) an existing heading is being split into two or more new headings. If any of these conditions is met, submit a proposal to delete the record, as follows:

E.1. Retrieving the heading in the ClassWeb Plus Subject Heading Proposal System

Retrieve the subject heading that is to be deleted. Click on the icon to the right of the heading in the browse display, and in the dropdown menu click "Propose cancelling this heading."

E.2. "Generated by"

At the top of the form select the appropriate radio button from the four options. See H 200 sec. D.1 for definitions of the options.

E.3. Explanation of the cancellation

Add a 682 field to the record with an $i subfield containing an appropriate note explaining why the record is being deleted. Select this note from the list provided in H 193.5.

E.4. Saving and viewing the record

Save the revised record to the Subject Heading Proposal System by clicking on the wrench icon in the upper right-hand corner to reveal the Tools menu and clicking the Save button. The proposed deletion is now searchable within the system. Search for the proposed heading in the browse display. The text of the heading is displayed in brown, indicating that it is a proposed deletion and not yet approved.

E.5. Submitting the proposal

Submit the proposal to PTCP according to the instructions in H 200 sec. G. Once the proposal(s) have been submitted to PTCP, make no further changes to the online authority records in the Subject Heading Proposal System. If any further additions or changes are required, notify PTCP by email at policy@loc.gov.

F. Changes that do not require a proposal

There are select changes that can be made to subject heading records outside the proposal process. Changes that can (usually) be made off list include:

- Changes to classification numbers listed in the 053 field (add, delete, or change)

- Corrections of typographical errors
- Updates to Subd Geog status
- Addition of citations (670s)

Requests for off list changes can be emailed to Policy, Training, and Cooperative Programs Division at policy@loc.gov. The policy specialists will evaluate the request and, if approved, make the change directly to the subject authority record. These will not be high-priority changes, but will be handled as workload allows.

Revision history

2026-04: Added information on making associated changes and defining projects.

2025-04: Updated to current template. Added definitions, slightly reorganized sections, and added new section on changes that do not require a proposal.